In 2002, the company won a $100 million contract with GE Medical Systems to provide a complete range of global information technology services and solutions. The deal was the ‘largest single contract ever won by an Indian software services company till then’.

The following year, TCS crossed the milestone of $1 billion in annual revenue. With 90 per cent of it coming from IT services, it drew up a strategic plan to ‘capture more market share’ and ‘expand the services’. Pursuing Ratan’s emphasis on expanding the Tatas’ global footprint, it also unrolled an ambitious plan to find a slot in the list of ‘Top 10 by 2010’ among global companies, in terms of revenue, market capitalization and profitability. In pursuance of this goal, it expanded its operations to include ‘Global Consulting, Engineering and Industrial Services, Asset-based Offerings, Infrastructure Services and IT-enabled Services (or BPO)’ and aimed to grow into a ‘$1 billion plus business’.

In 2004, TCS forged an alliance with Japanese IT company Fujitsu and bagged a £896 million contract to revamp the information technology structure of the National Health Services (NHS) of the UK. Continuing its quest for expansion, it snapped up Phoenix Global Solutions, a global provider of technology-business solutions to insurance companies, from the US-based Phoenix Companies Inc. Its bold ambition to be part of the top ten global IT companies in the next six years and the steps it embraced to achieve this saw its income almost double in three years (2001–04) from Rs 3,157 crore to Rs 6,138 crore.

The IPO: A ‘Masterpiece of a Decision’

As TCS’s performance continued to dazzle, the question of it being listed became a hot topic of discussion in the Indian capital markets. Credit Suisse First Boston had valued the company at Rs 97,000 crore, which gave considerable room for excitement in Bombay House. The company too had been internally debating the issue for some years. In 2000, Ratan revealed that the listing was under serious consideration but refused to commit to a time frame.

He said, ‘We are in fact looking at this, but it must make sense to us. Merely to go public, to get a higher market cap in itself is not what is driving us.’ He clarified that the company would not take the path ‘for the sake of making a noise’. As it was the ‘largest provider of cash flow to Tata